

GOVIND LALJIBHAI DHOLAKIA, 74

Surat, Gujarat

Company
Shree Ramkrishna Exports Pvt Ltd

Net Worth
Rs 4,800 crore

A Cut Above the Rest

Known as GLD in business circles and Govind *kaka* at home, Govind Laljibhai Dholakia was born in a remote village in Gujarat and grew up working on a farm. When he came to Surat in 1964, "I'd work 14 hours a day," he says, "like the 200-300 other diamond polishers in the city." One could turn only 28 per cent of the rough stone into a finished diamond, but with persistence and scientific cutting, Dholakia managed to salvage 34 per cent, making it a bigger gem of higher value. "But my employer asked me to replace it with a smaller one. I refused," he recalls. It became a trigger for him to start his own company, Shree Ramkrishna Exports, in 1970.

Where he invests profits
Back into business or in charitable ventures

Located in Katargam—the heart of the global diamond trade in Surat—the six-storey SRK Empire and the adjacent nine-storey SRK House serve as the company headquarters. With 6,000 employees, a turnover of Rs 16,000 crore in 2021-22, the company boasts a clientele that includes Tanishq and De Beers.

His success has made Dholakia popular in the B-school circuit, where he lectures about both his growth and values.

-Jumana Shah